Patient A

By Lee Blessing

KIMBERLY: For those of you who don't know who I am- my name is. . . was. . . Kimberly Ann Mary Bergalis. I'm using the past tense by the way, out of respect for myself. The whole ordeal began quite innocently. In the middle of my junior year at the University of Florida, I had to have two back molars removed by Dr. Acer. While it was an involved appointment, I don't remember much about it that was unusual, besides that it hurt. I did not know that less than four years later, I'd be dead.

INTRODUCTION

Out of the nearly 200,000 people who have developed AIDS in the U.S., only five are known to have been infected by a health-care worker. Epidemiologists quickly point out that all five cases can be traced to the same Florida dentist, David Acer. But the fact remains that it did happen, despite the odds and with devastating results. One of Acer's patients, Kimberly Bergalis, ultimately died of AIDS related complications. Her plight and her understandable fury have moved millions to feel insecure when they go for teeth cleaning or an annual physical exam.

Today, nearly 6,800 health-care workers in the U.S. are known to have AIDS -- including 170 dentists and dental hygienists, 730 physicians and more than 1,450 nurses. Should they tell patients? Should they get out of medicine altogether?

Patient A by Lee Blessing is based on this very real social issue as told through the eyes of Kimberly Bergalis.

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KIMBERLY: I started to feel sick in spring of 1989. I went to a hematologist. They took blood, ran a lot of tests- no HIV test, though. I began to have problems breathing. I went to a hematologist/ oncologist, who examined me for cancer. I didn't have cancer. The doctors wondered if I was just hyperventilating. Our local doctor diagnosed me with bilateral pneumocystis pneumonia and had me hospitalized. Oh, yes---For the first time I was tested for HIV. Five days after I turned twenty-two, the results came back positive.

The doctor gave me some time alone, before my folks came in. I began to cry. I looked out the window, and the clouds were moving against the sun, swirling. I heard a voice that said it

would all be ok. That everyone in the family would be able to handle it. And I opened my eyes and no one was in the room.

My mother was the first to come in. She talked about her own parents, who'd been killed years before in a car accident and how they'd be waiting in heaven for me, along with Grandma Zebleckas and even their dog that died, too. I think if she could have put everything that ever lived into heaven for me in that moment she would have. When we'd calmed down, my father came in. That was harder. He shook and he cried.

"Oh my God, no. No, please. . . Put your head on my shoulder. . . It's gonna be ok. We're gonna get through this." He kept saying it had to be a mistake, that he didn't believe it, that it can't be. It just can't be.

"Dad, it is."

My case was reported to the state agency and also to the Centers for Disease Control in Atlanta. They couldn't figure out how I'd been infected. I didn't have any of the usual risk factors. I hadn't had any transfusions. I wasn't a drug user or hemophiliac. They ended up asking about some pretty unusual things.

CDC: How many people have you had intercourse with?

KIMBERLY: None.

CDC: I'm talking about sex, now. Sexual-

KIMBERLY: None. *(beat)* They had a hard time believing that I'd never had intercourse. It was my mother who first thought of Dr. Acer. There'd been rumors about him. Some people thought he had AIDS. So we mentioned it to the CDC. I was never told they were investigating the dentist.

Seven months after I was diagnosed, Jane Pauley had a message for me on the evening news. A young woman in Florida had in all likelihood been infected with HIV by her dentist. No one had called to tell me this would be on. This was the first moment I realized they'd been lying to me all along- staring me right in the eye, knowing I had a disease that was going to kill me, and refusing to tell me the truth.

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You don't know what to think when you've got this disease. The best experts in the country can't tell you how you got it. Meanwhile, you're hiding it from as many people as possible, you're going through a kind of terror you've never known, you feel guilty. You feel as you somehow betrayed your family, because you see their pain. And you yourself- somehow you betrayed yourself. You failed to take care of yourself. But how? How?

I was called Patient A, since my name was off-limits. Then two of Dr. Acer's other patients tested positive and we had Patients B and C. It felt insulting. As though they'd decided never to speak my name again.

I think the insurance company really thought about going to court until the other two patients were discovered. After that, the company agreed to a million dollar settlement.

This was a relatively good time for my family. We were suddenly famous. we'd won this big settlement, and I was still to have a lot of good days physically.

I did get to do a few things I had never done before. I got to ride in a hot air balloon in Palm Springs. That was the best. Floating, for a few minutes, it seemed like a different planet. I started to imagine who might live down there. Maybe it was people who were not greedy, not vicious, not afraid. Maybe they felt pain when others suffered, joy when the others succeeded. Impossible people, walking gracefully beneath the palms,] grateful just to be walking there at all. Then suddenly the balloon made a jump, and I looked up and thought, "Here I am suspended above my dreams by nothing more than heat." It felt like riding in the hand of God--that gentle, that terrifying. And somehow I knew that wherever that hand took me, frightened as I was, it would never let me go.

I called a few people bastards before I died, and frankly I don't regret it. I resented what the dentist did, but more than that I resented the authorities who told him he had a right to keep practicing and keep his secret. After all, when you die for a public health policy, I think you have the right to question it pretty strenuously.

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Not long after floating in the balloon, I took a turn for the worse. Hospital, transfusion---When I left the hospital this time, I started keeping a diary on tape. I'd lie on the coach all day making tapes. Sometimes, I'd talk to my sisters. Allison held up really well, but Sondra cried a lot. She was only eleven. I would have to think of things to cheer her up.

In the end, I was afraid to go to sleep, because I was afraid I wouldn't wake-up.

My Mom brought up a good point. She said, "Why are you so sure that it's not going to get any worse?" And that's something I never thought about. I just thought how I can't take this pain anymore, and how I want to be out of my misery before it gets worse. So that made me think. I started thinking about the cemetery where I was going to be buried, and all the names-

- And how I am going to lie right next to my Grandmother on the top of a mountain—
- And how I am going to lift up and just fly away into the heavens.
- And how God's going to come down and take my hand---
- And how my body's just going to be this thing I used while I was on this Earth.
- And then a peace came over me and I was finally able to sleep.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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